
Considering Computer Games as a Replacement for Thought Experiments in Ethics II: The Solution

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[...]

A deadly disease emerged in a remote town deep in the eastern wastelands: undetectable, incurable, and lethal. [...] It took to twelve days until the town was no more.

Doctor 1: "So tell me, could the tragic events have been prevented?"

Doctor 2: "Truth is, he can't answer you. He has to find the answer himself."

Doctor 3: "So we give you a tool for that: *a stress behavior simulator*."

Doctor 1: "Think of it as a vaccine for your mind. By putting you in a terrible situation, we are forcing you to make a decision more quickly."

Doctor 3: "Doesn't it help you to get a better understanding of yourself?"

The best way to create a believable simulation, capable of creating the sense of a contaminated environment, is building a game.

from "**Feverish Feeling**" by Ice-Pick Lodge¹.

Introduction

Previously I argued that it is a problematic practice in philosophy to build arguments from **physical experiments**, i.e. thought experiments based on physical possibilities². I admitted to an Aristotelean ethical standpoint to argue that the two main issues with such a practice are the problems of efficient isolation and temporal urgency³. Both of these problems are mainly due to the hardship of constituting a so-called "minimal working example". We need thought experiments that are concise, yet powerful enough to constitute and test ethical theories. Keeping thought experiments concise, however, renders them very open to interpretation to be of any use, while trying to make them powerful enough proves to be impractically cumbersome within the confinements of physical possibilities. A particularly important implication of this can be thought of as intrinsic to the medium itself: presenting a thought experiment in a form to be read suppresses the weight of making an ethical decision as well as the temporal urgency often included in it. The general problem is the problem of efficient isolation and the more specific problem is the problem of temporal urgency.

However this is not to say that thought experiments are completely useless. They can provide good toy examples as long as they are not too far fetched. For instance trolley is far fetched because intrinsic to the experiment there is an expected ethical calculus yet no (sound) ethical

¹This video can be seen as promotional material for their survival adventure game *Pathologic*. This game is the quintessential example I have in mind throughout this essay (and actually throughout the previous essay as well), though giving it as a precise example for my claim would be a little off: it is not made by, say, an (academic) philosopher so that he can wholeheartedly use it as a ludic experiment to write a paper on the relevance—or irrelevance—of ethics in survival situations of somewhat influential possibly responsible agents. It is made by a game company to be a ludic experiment for the player (and to be at least financially profitable).

²As before, **bold** signifies the word or phrase being defined and sans serif signifies the name of a thought experiment. *Italics* emphasize. In virtue of the first footnote I refrain from writing *Pathologic* or *Pathologic*.

³This was the main thesis of my midterm essay for PHIL 216.

calculus operates on abstract people that have no specific characteristics, say faces or the basic ability to sense that a trolley is coming towards them either by hearing or by seeing or by sensing the vibrations in the rail via touching; and judge is far fetched because it is absurd to even think of a judge who holds such a judiciary position and consider blaming an innocent person and potentially risk his career. What is needed is to establish some criterion to keep the use of thought experiments regulated. Hereby I propose to make use of certain machinery from game studies to determine such a criterion, which I call **gameplay possibility**. I call a thought experiment to be **based on ludic (or gameplay) possibility**⁴ if the following two conditions are satisfied:

LE1 (Potentiality) There can be a well-made ethically notable computer game that includes the thought experiment.

LE2 (Designability) The user of the thought experiment (e.g. a philosopher) does justice to the potentiality in LE1.

In LE1 the phrase "well-made" is in the sense of a computer game as an artifact. To be sure, the question "What makes a game well-made (i.e. good as an artifact)?" should be given a thorough answer, however this is more towards game studies, to be specific towards game design theory. Hence for this essay it suffices to give (the remnants of) a basic answer: a computer game is **well-made** if it has "strong gameplay, impressive graphics or simply are just plain fun"⁵; or put differently, if it is "balanced and enjoyable"⁶. Admittedly here I am only shifting (and dividing) ambiguity from one term to (and into) other terms, though a vague sense is sufficient for an essay in ethics. In any case, I take the term "well-made" so that *Pathologic* is considered to be well-made. LE1 will almost always be satisfied, by stretching the definitions if necessary.

While LE1 contains all the important definitions, what I am suggesting to be a remedy for the problem at hand is really the designability component (LE2) of a ludic experiment. One can do justice to the potentiality of a well-made computer game either by actually producing a computer game, which is the best case scenario, or by simply providing enough details to produce a computer game. Similar crossovers of philosophy with other disciplines, especially with literature, is not unheard of, e.g. Dostoyevsky's *Notes from Underground*, where he can be considered to philosophize for the first third of the book and spend the rest for fleshing out an accompanying thought experiment⁷. It can be said that such works in the tradition of philosophy can just as well be thought of as part of the tradition of literature, and perhaps even if there is not necessarily literary precedence certainly literature and philosophy go hand in hand

⁴Such thought experiments will be called **ludic experiments**.

⁵[Rey02] Observe that *Pathologic* can hardly be considered to have impressive graphics or to be fun, though it definitely has strong gameplay.

⁶[Sic05]

⁷As can be anticipated I would claim that this is not a coincidence: thought experiments require details.

in such works⁸. This could be a problem—except computer games could be considered as narrative mediums just as novels⁹, and computer games can generate philosophical discussions. To be specific, creating an "ethically notable computer game" is very closely related to this last point.

Once we justify LE1 and LE2, ludic experiments will be seen as the solution to the posed problem. LE2 is established easily: One requires some computer game literacy and some understanding of computer game design. Since computer games already started to mature—and will continue to mature in increasing speed for quite a while—as a standalone medium I believe both of these skills will prove to be beneficial, say for philosophers, just as general knowledge of, say Greek tragedy or American poetry or film history and theory is beneficial, though it is very likely that computer game literacy will outweigh such additional competences. I could, instead of suggesting a ludic experiment, suggest a **literary experiment**, where the thought experiment is based on a literary work, fictional or otherwise¹⁰. In that case I would have to say, "well, you gotta be able to write, or at least have a sense of what details should be added etc., for this to work!". LE2 is analogous to this necessity.

Hence it suffices to justify LE1. I claimed before that LE1 is almost always satisfied due to the ambiguity of the terms, but actually a concrete account for it can be provided via game studies. For this two things need to be clarified:

- Ⓘ For any thought experiment there can be a well-made game.
- Ⓜ Games can be made to be ethically notable.

Juul's Abstraction

Ⓘ is justified by Juul's concept of "abstraction"¹¹, of which he distinguishes three different senses:

Abstraction as Design Not everything can be simulated in a computer game. The "virtual" or "simulation" is seen as the mean of a purely axiomatic system and a purely fictional narrative. "The **level of abstraction** is the level on which the player can act: The actions that are available to the player."¹². In other words, the level of abstraction determines the distribution of emphasis to the rules of the game and the fiction of the game. In *Pathologic* one can obtain a handgun and bullets to shoot, but he can not shoot himself, and there is nothing wrong with this limitation: it is a fundamental design element. In contrast, there

⁸For instance Voltaire's opposition to Leibnizian optimism and his *Candide*.

⁹[DyLe05, Rey02] They are actually more than narrative mediums, due to "the unique properties of game interactivity".

¹⁰Note that this would be a marginally weaker claim, by way of game interactivity, which any other medium lacks.

¹¹[Juu07]

¹²[Juu07]

is no analogous criteria whatsoever for trolley: it is almost impossible to convince one that there really are two and only two options to choose from.

Abstraction as Experience Even though it is certain that there is some abstraction, the player initially is unaware of the level of it. He evaluates and readjusts the level while he is exploring the opportunities the game provides.

Abstraction as Optimization As the player becomes more comfortable playing the game he can further readjust the level of abstraction to fit his needs, e.g. for competitive gaming this could mean to consider the game as a purely axiomatic system.

Observe that abstraction in the first sense corresponds to the building of a "sphere of actualization" I mentioned in the previous essay. To give an example, in trolley one might consider whether one is the driver or happens to be seated in the driver's seat to be irrelevant to the ethical consequences of the decision to be made, and by abstraction as design it is legitimate that the player can not look anywhere but straight ahead. Moreover, Juul declares that one obtains the perspective of the designer or the theorist when one exhausts the game completely, i.e. masters abstraction in the second sense:

[T]he player's view of the game changes over time, while playing the game. The designer's or theorist's view of the game is a retrospective view, the view of an ideal player that has spent all the time needed in the game and discovered all its secrets.¹³

Recall further that in the previous essay I argued that ethics is more retrospective than prospective. This, as well as the notion of a sphere of actualization, were both available since we committed to an Aristotelean ethical framework, which demonstrates that I am being faithful to the setup from the first essay. Moreover the constitution of a sphere of actualization as well as the designer's or theorist's view being retrospective further strengthen LE2 and guarantee that what I am developing here is in accordance with our philosophical needs. All this discussion about abstraction clarifies why the following definition justifies (I):

[A]bstraction can be seen as the process by which *any* given subject matter is transformed into game form.¹⁴

In particular any logical and physical experiment (or any other kind of thought experiment for that matter) can be extended to a game, which I call **gamifying**¹⁵ a thought experiment¹⁶.

Ethically Notable Computer Games

The following machinery from game studies will be sufficient to justify (II):

¹³[Juul07]

¹⁴[Juul07]

¹⁵This is somewhat related to the concept of "gamification" from game studies, but for this essay we can ignore the necessity of comparing these two concepts.

¹⁶In this regard gamifiability is similar to the Kantian idea of universalizability—except gamifiability actually makes sense (to me at least).

(Z) Zagal defines a computer game to be **ethically notable** if it "provide[s] opportunities for encouraging ethical reasoning and reflection"¹⁷. The most straightforward way of making an ethically notable game is to implement moral dilemmas.

(S) Sicart argues that a value system can be built in any artifact¹⁸. In light of the moral dilemmas from (Z), Sicart's ethical game design can be generalized to an ambiguously ethical (or ethically-ambiguous) game design, where there are at least two different "right" choices for any decision presented to the player¹⁹.

(R) Reynolds declares that the interactivity the medium provides is naturally in alignment with virtue ethics²⁰.

First let me explain (Z). As I mentioned before various types of media can provide ethically notable works. The reason why they work so well is because they have the power to make the audience commit to what they have to offer, both intellectually and emotionally. Physical experiments lack especially the power to make one commit to the decision emotionally. In particular computer games have the power to deliver an immersive experience, where the player is not simply observing but *actively transforming* how the simulation unravels. The corresponding notion related to Juul's abstraction is "will to fiction":

[T]he player's attitude towards a game cannot be simply reduced to one of optimization: The player may also possess a certain *will to fiction*: many players *desire* make-believe.²¹

If, further, moral dilemmas can be implemented in the game—they certainly *can* by (S), then we obtain an ethically notable game, where "[a] **moral dilemma** is a situation in which an agent morally ought to do A and morally ought to do B but cannot do both, either because B is just not-doing-A or because some contingent feature of the world prevents doing both."²². Among all ethically notable media, moral dilemmas find their natural place when they are implemented in computer games:

The dilemma faced by the character is, by definition, one step removed and thus potentially less powerful or effective for eliciting ethical reflection.²³

For (S) it is enough to consider Sicart's "ethical labyrinth"²⁴. Initially a labyrinth is nothing more than a topographical puzzle, which requires the player (its audience) to find the right path to the exit. Then this concept is extended to an ethical labyrinth, "in which the choice for a route implies a moral decision"²⁵. For instance (*skinacatlab*) one can consider a labyrinth consisting

¹⁷[Zag09]

¹⁸[Sic05]

¹⁹This demonstrates why I consider *Pathologic* to be quintessential.

²⁰[Rey02]

²¹[Juu07]

²²[Zag09]

²³[Zag09]

²⁴[Sic05]

²⁵[Sic05]

of two routes A and B, where A is marginally longer than B, but B is closed off by a gate which by construction will only open if the player decides to skin a cat (the cat is chained and the gate has sensors etc.). Of course we are also implementing a time limit, which rushes the player to get out of the labyrinth in due time, otherwise the game will terminate. So far we have built only a physical experiment (such a labyrinth can be built). Sicart argues that this experiment can be gamified by noting that a computer game is an "ergodic work of art":

An **ergodic work of art** "is one that in a material sense includes the rules for its own use".²⁶

A computer game is an ergodic artifact since it is by definition coded. But the code of the game is not necessarily experienced by the player as code itself but architecture, since simulation can not escape spatiality:

Code is the material string of commands that constitute an ergodic artifact. **Architecture** is the implementation of that code in a concrete experience.²⁷

Thus ethical values, or their ambiguity thereof, can be included in a game at its code level, and this will generate an architecture with ethical values, or ethical ambiguity, imprinted to it. Sicart only claims the imprinting of ethical values to a computer game, and consequently traps himself, or at least the designers who don't think of coding ambiguity, to admit that this is problematic:

The problem with this approach is that morality is not algorithmical. Ethics cannot be evaluated with a fuzzy numeric quantification hardwired in the code.²⁸

Recall that Aristotelean ethics emphasizes becoming rather than knowing, and that at the kernel of it is activity²⁹. The precedence of actively transforming over observing mentioned in (Z) mirrors this, as does the agency provided to the player via the architecture of a game in (S). Finally (R) amalgamates all the previous machinery together to be seen in accordance with Aristotelean ethics:

What's fascinating about this approach is that it gets straight to the heart of computer games' unique nature—their interactivity. The fact that a video game is necessarily interactive means that if we play a game we must make choices. [...] we make choices within the game itself—*these choices are the game*.³⁰

(II), and so LE1 as well are therefore justified.

Conclusion

Observe that LE1 also includes, at least partially, the claim that in-game actions are worthy of ethical consideration, though I must remark that for this we actually need a thorough ontolog-

²⁶[Sic05]

²⁷[Sic05]

²⁸[Sic05]

²⁹In the previous essay I argued that at the kernel is being a virtuous person, but I consider these to be the same by way of habituation.

³⁰[Rey02] The emphasis is mine.

ical account of computer games (if not of digital environments in general). For the sake of this essay a shortcut to this project would be to invoke some kind of intuition along with Juul's will to fiction. Surely I am not going to argue that killing a person in a computer game is as bad as killing a person in real life, be that person be controlled by another player or by artificial intelligence. However I believe it is safe to assume that these two actions are incomparable, and that even if real decisions are marginally heavier, in-game decisions are not weightless, at least certainly as weightless as physical experiments seem to be.

The ludic experiments I have presented here are stronger than any other kind of experiment I mentioned due to gamifiability. Further, the extension I propose is canonical: it is in accordance with the crossover tradition of philosophy and it is well adapted to the modern times. The solution is hereby delivered.

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